KEEPING OPEN BOOKS USABLE

Challenges and opportunities for preserving e-theses and open scholarly outputs

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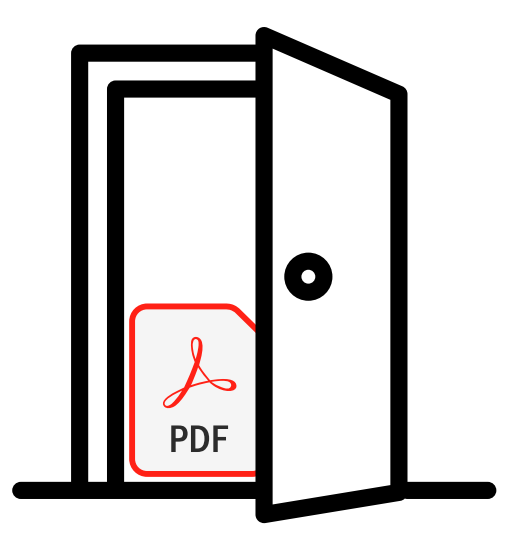
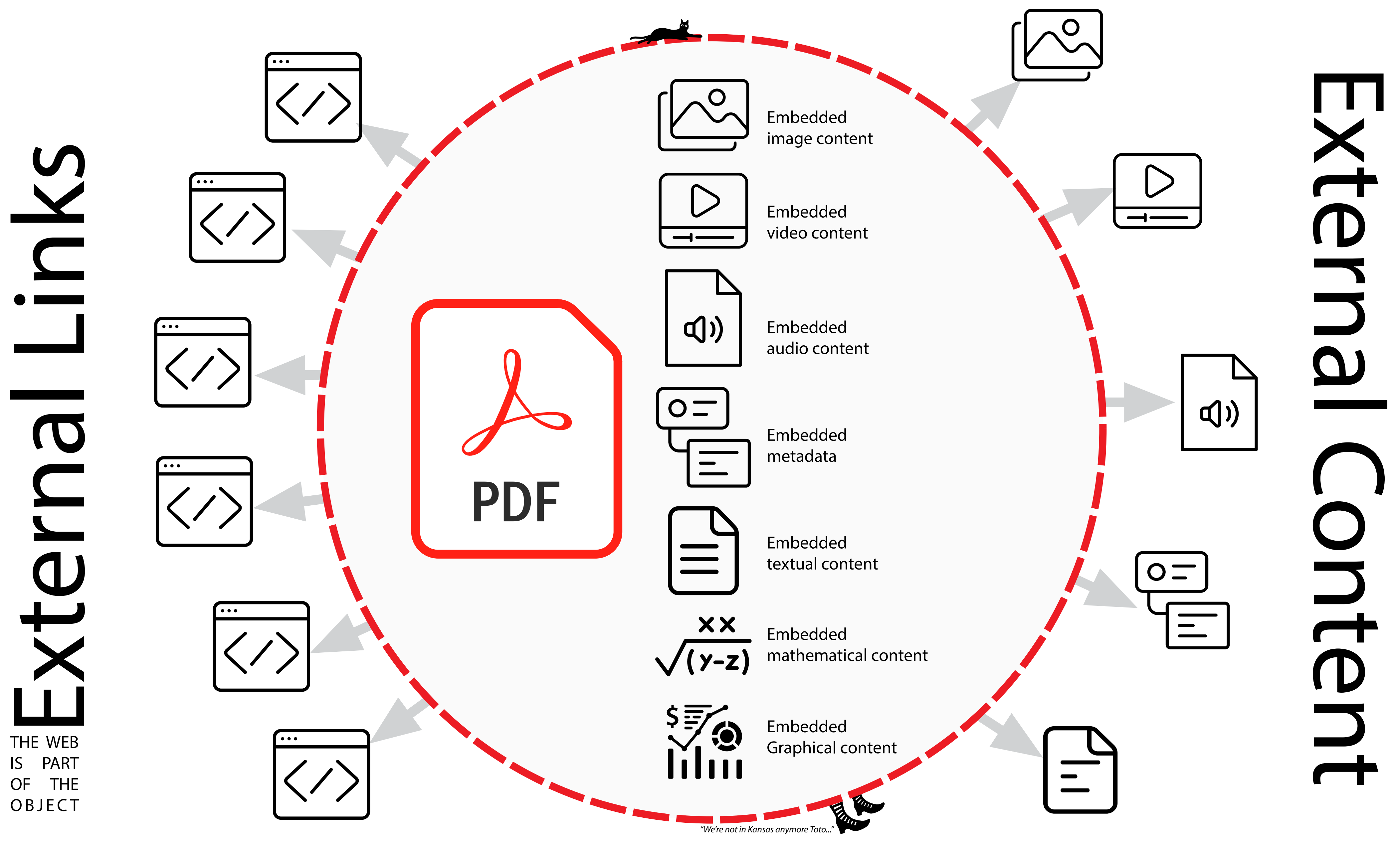


The core challenge

An e-thesis is no longer just a simple PDF—a picture of a document. It is a complex digital research object that needs preservation from the outset and policy to facilitate that preservation.



What we found...

84 Usable doctoral researcher survey responses

13 Participants in five university group interviews

37% Text-based thesis *with supplementary files*

27% Text-based thesis *with substantial embedded multimedia*

87% Want to learn how to prepare e-theses for long-term preservation

37% Get no guidance

39% e-theses preservation covered by institutional policies

30% Unsure about policy existence

25% No e-theses preservation policy

Four gaps—one systemic problem...

01 PERCEPTION
What are we actually preserving?

02 POLICY & RESPONSIBILITY
Who is responsible — and for what?

03 TECHNICAL PRACTICE
Can current systems preserve the object?

04 SKILLS & TRAINING
Do people know what to do, and when?

CREATION → SUBMISSION → DEPOSIT → PRESERVATION → REUSE

Five principles for resilient open scholarship...

01 DEFINE
Know what the object is

02 DECIDE
Determine what *must* survive

03 DESCRIBE
Make dependencies visible

04 PRESERVE
Build resilience into the workflow

05 REVIEW
What are we actually preserving?

The trust layer...

The OBF Open Archiving criteria say that:

- OA content should remain openly available;
- OA metadata should be openly available;
- preservation processes should be openly verifiable;
- operational practices should be evidenced and documented;
- risk registers should encompass political, geographical and legislative risks, not just technical risks.

ACCESS
Can I get it?

INTEGRITY
Can I trust it?

EVIDENCE
understand how it was preserved?

What should change?

01 POLICY
Align the sector

- UK-wide consistency
- Clarify stewardship responsibilities
- Align preservation with e-thesis policies
- Address associated digital materials

02 PEOPLE
Build capability early

- Training for doctoral researchers
- Training for supervisors
- Upskill repository staff
- Embed preservation literacy earlier

03 WORKFLOW
Preserve from the outset

- Treat e-theses as complex digital objects
- Integrate preservation into the doctoral lifecycle
- Manage associated research materials
- Plan for long-term usability, not just submission

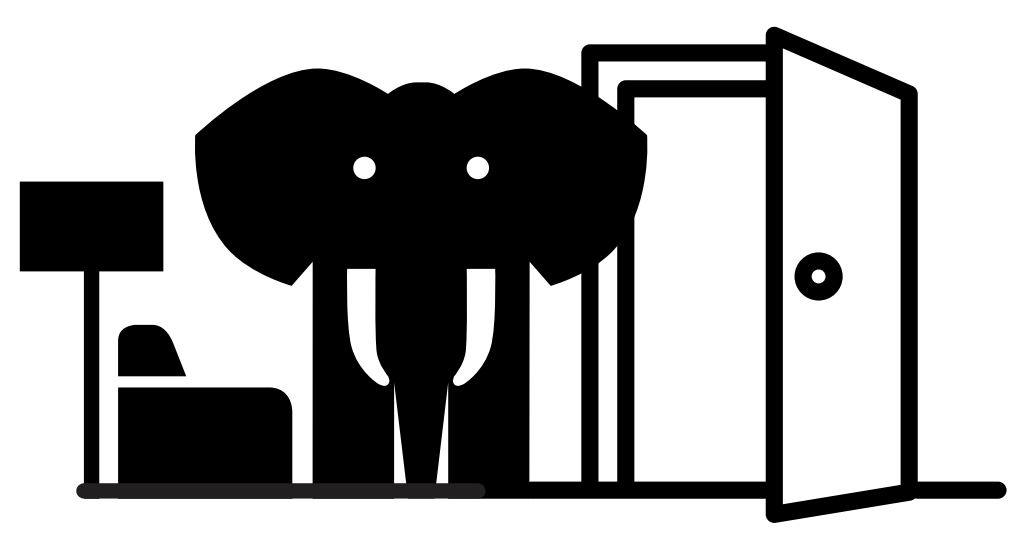
START EARLY → ALIGN → SUSTAIN

WE PRESERVE FOR USE — NOT JUST TO KEEP “STUFF”

Start preservation early. Define the object. Make dependencies visible. Clarify responsibility. Build resilience into workflows.

Open access is an access condition
Preservation is a lifecycle commitment

Who is going to fund all of this?



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